

ANDRÉ DELGADO DIAZ

SIMPLICITY, GENDER & THE ART OF MAKING

For André Delgado Diaz, a third-year fashion design student at Parsons, gender isn't something to define; it's something to be felt. "It's simple," she says. "Femininity and masculinity aren't opposites. They're just energies in motion. More like actions than traits."

Born in Michigan and raised in California, André has always seen self-expression as something natural and intuitive, not performative. "I've always been the same," she says. "I could've lied to myself... but honestly, no. Never. Which is strange." She laughs softly, reflecting on the way the world often expects transformation stories. "It's a strange thing to know your identity but not love yourself yet. I know who I am. What I still figure out is where I fit."

That quiet awareness started early. In middle school, she remembers spending forty-five minutes every morning styling her hair, doing what she thought she was supposed to do. "Older people would compliment me on my hair, but people in my grade were like, what?" she says. "It was because I was doing it for everyone else." By the end of that year, she let it go. "It was the first time I did something just for me."

The real turning point came a little later, a scene from Pose, where Angel talks about buying a red pump from Sears. "That was it," André says, smiling. "I got happy chills. It was like something unlocked in my brain."

Now, André views gender as something deeply human, a lived energy that doesn't need to be over-explained. "People make gender complicated," she says. "For me, it's just intuitive. Natural. I don't have to prove it or perform it."

As a designer, that philosophy bleeds into everything she makes. "I'm a maker. Even when I was scared, I made things," she says. "I see inspiration like a spiderweb with droplets, small ideas connected by invisible threads. I pull from everywhere and somehow it all fits together." She pauses, describing how this web-like process mirrors the way she sees identity itself: fluid, layered, connected.

Outside of design, André leads the Fashion Act Facilitation Alliance (FAF), a student group focused on sustainability and policy change within the fashion industry. "Fashion and the environment have always been in conflict," she says. "I love nature. I want to make it in a cyclical way, using what already exists

instead of taking more." For André, creativity and activism aren't separate. "Making things should never mean harming what made us."

When the conversation turns toward trans visibility, the conversation gets heavier as André explains "I think what's missing from the mainstream conversation about trans people is our humanity," she says. "We're sensationalized, mythologized, objectified, because that's what society does with femininity. It dehumanizes it to control it."

"She sees misogyny as the root of transphobia and homophobia," an iceberg," as she calls it, "with misogyny sitting right underneath." Choosing to live authentically as a trans woman, she explains, is still seen as a threat to masculinity and control. "But in reality, most trans women just want to be human — to have a boyfriend, friends, a family. It's not rebellion. It's life."

In person, André moves between reflection and laughter with ease; grounded but curious. When asked what self-expression feels like for her, she doesn't hesitate. "Instinctive," she says. "I don't overthink it. My art already knows what I want to say."

Support, to her, doesn't come from slogans, it comes from action. "I feel the best when people compliment my work," she says. "Support people's actions, their intentions, what they make. That's how you show love."

As our conversation winds down, André comes back to the same idea she started with the simplicity of being. "Gender doesn't need to be explained," she says, smiling. "It's just something you live with."

credits	
creator	André Delgado Diaz
photos	Malcom Mills
writing	Liv Russo
layout design	Finley Banks*
medium	Interview

